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### Vertical curtain blind and related connector clips and panels for use with a vertical curtain blind

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#### Abstract

A vertical curtain blind includes a panel assembly having a plurality of individual panels coupled together in a side-by-side arrangement. Each panel extends in a vertical direction between a top end and a bottom end. Additionally, each panel includes first and second pockets positioned along first and second sides of the panel, respectively, adjacent to the top end of the panel. The blind associated includes a plurality of clip assemblies, with each clip assembly being configured to couple a respective pair of adjacent panels of the plurality of panels together. Each clip assembly includes a first connector clip positioned within the first pocket of a first panel of the respective pair of adjacent panels and a second connector clip positioned within the second pocket of an adjacent second panel of the respective pair of adjacent panels, with the first connector clip configured to be coupled to the second connector clip.

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#### Background/Summary

PRIORITY CLAIM (1) The present application is a continuation of U.S. Non-Provisional Patent Application Ser. No. 17/396,138, filed Sep. 6, 2021, which is based upon and claims the right of priority to U.S. Provisional Patent Application No. 63/065,178, filed Aug. 13, 2020. Applicant claims priority to and the benefit of each of such applications and incorporates all such applications herein by reference in its entirety.

## FIELD

(1) The present subject matter relates generally to window coverings for architectural structures and, more particularly, to a vertical curtain blind or drapery including connector clips for coupling adjacent panels of the blind to each other as well as coupling the panels to mounting hardware to suspend the blind from an associated rail or track.

## BACKGROUND

(2) Draperies or vertical curtain blinds are a popular type of covering used in residential and commercial applications to cover a window, door, and/or other architectural structures. Various types or configurations of vertical curtain blinds have been developed over the years. For example, vertical curtain blinds are commercially available that include a plurality of panels configured to be suspended relative to a track or headrail. In some instances, the panels have a hybrid configuration including both light-transmitting sections and light-blocking sections. In such instances, the panels are typically configured to be tilted to adjust the light-transmitting/blocking state of the blind.

(3) With such blinds, it is known to suspend the individual panels from the associated track or headrail using clamp-type connectors. For example, US Patent Publication No. 2017/0354285 (Kim) discloses connectors for a blind-type curtain that are configured to clamp-over the top ends of adjacent panels to allow the panels to be suspended from an associated rail. However, such clamp-type connectors suffer from various drawbacks. For instance, the connection between the connectors and the associated rail mounting hardware is positioned significantly above the top ends of the panels, thereby creating the potential for large light gaps between the panels and the rail. Moreover, given their exterior clamping configuration, the connectors are clearly visible along the top ends of the panels, which can be an undesirable aesthetic for many consumers.

(4) Accordingly, a vertical curtain blind having improved connectors for coupling adjacent panels of the blind to each other as well as coupling the panels to mounting hardware to suspend the blind from an associated rail or track would be welcomed in the technology. In addition, related panel configurations for accommodating the improved connectors would also be welcomed in the technology.

## BRIEF SUMMARY

(5) Aspects and advantages of the present subject matter will be set forth in part in the following description, or may be obvious from the description, or may be learned through practice of the present subject matter.

(6) In one aspect, the present subject matter is directed to a vertical curtain blind. The blind includes a panel assembly having a plurality of individual panels coupled together in a side-by-side arrangement. Each panel extends in a vertical direction between a top end and a bottom end. Additionally, each panel includes first and second pockets positioned along first and second sides of the panel, respectively, adjacent to the top end of the panel. The blind associated includes a plurality of clip assemblies, with each clip assembly being configured to couple a respective pair of adjacent panels of the plurality of panels together. Each clip assembly includes a first connector clip positioned within the first pocket of a first panel of the respective pair of adjacent panels and a second connector clip positioned within the second pocket of an adjacent second panel of the respective pair of adjacent panels, with the first connector clip configured to be coupled to the second connector clip.

(7) In another aspect, the present subject matter is directed to a clip assembly for removably coupling adjacent panels of a vertical curtain blind together. The clip assembly includes a first connector clip having a first clip body extending in a lengthwise direction between a first end and a second end of the first connector clip and in a heightwise direction between a top side and a bottom side of the first connector clip. The first clip body includes connection structure. The clip assembly also includes a second connector clip having a second clip body extending in the lengthwise direction between a first end and a second end of the second connector clip and in the heightwise

direction between a top side and a bottom side of the second connector clip. The second clip body includes connection structure configured to engage the connection structure of the first connector clip to removably couple the first connector clip to the second connector clip. When the first and second connector clips are coupled together, a connection interface is defined between adjacent outer faces of the first and second connector clips. Additionally, at least one of the first connector clip or the second connector clip includes retention structure separate from the connection structures of the first and second connector clips that extends outwardly from an outer face of the at least one of the first connector clip or the second connector clip positioned opposite the connection interface defined between the first and second connector clips.

(8) In a further aspect, the present subject matter is directed to a panel for a vertical curtain blind, with the panel extending in a vertical direction between a top end and a bottom end of the panel. The panel includes a light-transmitting panel portion extending in the vertical direction between the top and bottom ends of the panel, and first and second light-blocking panel portions extending in the vertical direction between the top and bottom ends of the panel along opposed sides of the light-transmitting portion. In addition, the panel includes a first pocket extending laterally along the top end of the panel across at least a portion of the first light-blocking panel portion, and a second pocket extending laterally along the top end of the panel across at least a portion of the second light-blocking panel portion.

(9) These and other features, aspects, and advantages of the present subject matter will become better understood with reference to the following Detailed Description and appended claims. The accompanying drawings, which are incorporated in and constitute a part of this specification, illustrate embodiments of the present subject matter and, together with the description, serve to explain the principles of the present subject matter.

(10) This Brief Description is provided to introduce a selection of concepts in a simplified form that are further described below in the Detailed Description. This Brief Description is not intended to identify key features or essential features of the claimed subject matter, nor is it intended as an aid in determining the scope of the claimed subject matter.

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## Description

### BRIEF DESCRIPTION OF THE DRAWINGS

(1) A full and enabling disclosure of the present subject matter, including the best mode thereof, directed to one of ordinary skill in the art, is set forth in the specification, which makes reference to the appended figures, in which:

(2) FIG. 1 illustrates a perspective view of one embodiment of a vertical curtain blind in accordance with aspects of the present subject matter, particularly illustrating a panel assembly of the blind at an extended, opened position with one of the panels exploded away from the remainder of the panel assembly;

(3) FIG. 2 illustrates another perspective view of the vertical curtain blind shown in FIG. 1, particularly illustrating the panel assembly at a retracted position;

(4) FIG. 3 illustrates a further perspective view of the vertical curtain blind shown in FIG. 1, particularly illustrating the panel assembly at an extended, closed position;

(5) FIG. 4 illustrates a schematic view an upper portion of a panel suitable for use with a vertical curtain blind in accordance with aspects of the present subject matter;

(6) FIG. 5 illustrates a perspective view of one embodiment of connector clips of a clip assembly suitable for use in coupling adjacent panels of a vertical curtain blind together in accordance with aspects of the present subject matter;

(7) FIG. 6 illustrates another perspective view of the connector clips shown in FIG. 4, particularly illustrating the clips coupled to each other;

- (8) FIG. 7 illustrates a perspective view of adjacent panels of a vertical curtain blind and associated connector clips for coupling the panels together in accordance with aspects of the present subject matter, particularly illustrating the clips being installed within corresponding clip pockets of the panels;
- (9) FIG. 8 illustrates another perspective view of the panels and connector clips shown in FIG. 7, particularly illustrating the clips fully installed within corresponding clip pockets of the panels;
- (10) FIG. 9 illustrates a further perspective view of the panels and connector clips shown in FIGS. 7 and 8, particularly illustrating the panels coupled together in a side-by-side arrangement via the clips;
- (11) FIG. 10 illustrates a top view of three panels of a vertical curtain blind coupled together in a side-by-side arrangement with a clip assembly being used to couple each panel to an adjacent panel in accordance with aspects of the present subject matter; and
- (12) FIG. 11 illustrates a perspective view of another embodiment of connector clips of a clip assembly suitable for use in coupling adjacent panels of a vertical curtain blind together in accordance with aspects of the present subject matter;

#### DETAILED DESCRIPTION

(13) In general, the present subject matter is directed to a vertical curtain blind for an architectural feature or structure (referred to herein simply as an architectural “structure” for the sake of convenience and without intent to limit). In several embodiments, the vertical curtain blind includes a panel assembly formed from a plurality of individual panels coupled together in a side-by-side arrangement. In addition, the blind includes a clip assembly for coupling adjacent panels of the panel assembly together. The clip assembly includes first and second connector clips configured to be coupled to each other.

(14) In accordance with aspects of the present subject matter, each panel of the panel assembly includes first and second pockets positioned along opposed first and second sides of the panel, respectively. In such embodiments, the first connector clip of each clip assembly is configured to be positioned within the first pocket of a first panel of a respective pair of adjacent panels and the second connector clip is configured to be positioned within the second pocket of an adjacent second panel of the respective pair of adjacent panels. As a result, when the first and second connector clips are coupled together, the first and second panels may be similarly coupled together at the locations of their adjacent pockets (e.g., at the top ends of the panels).

(15) Advantageously, by configuring the connector clips to be received within pockets defined or formed in the panels, the clips can be entirely or substantially hidden from view when the various panels are assembled together to form the panel assembly. As a result, the assembled blind is very aesthetically appealing, particularly when compared to conventional blinds that include exterior, clamp-style connectors. Additionally, due to the pocket-based configuration, the connection provided between the clips and associated mounting hardware used to suspend the panel assembly relative to a corresponding rail or track is recessed below the top end of the panel assembly. As a result, the top end of the panel assembly may be positioned directly adjacent to the track thereby eliminating (or at least minimizing) light gaps between the panel assembly and the track.

(16) Referring now to the drawings, FIGS. 1-3 illustrate perspective views of one embodiment of a vertical curtain blind **100** configured for use as a covering for an architectural structure (e.g., indicated by dashed lines **102** in FIG. 2) in accordance with aspects of the present subject matter. In general, the blind **100** may correspond to a vertical covering (e.g., a vertical drapery) including a panel assembly **104** configured to be installed relative to a window, door, or other architectural structure as may be desired. In one embodiment, the panel assembly **104** may be placed in operative association with a head rail assembly, blind track assembly, a carrier assembly, or any other suitable support structure **106** that is configured to vertically support the panel assembly **104** relative to an architectural structure **102**. For instance, as shown in FIGS. 1-3, the panel assembly **104** may, for example, be suspended from a rail or track **107** of the support structure **106** relative to

the architectural structure **102** by a plurality of carriers or hangers **108**. As will be described in greater detail below, the panel assembly **104** is configured to be coupled to the various hangers **108** via associated connector clips **202** (FIG. **1**) installed within corresponding pockets of the panel assembly **104**. It should be understood that the disclosed blind **100** is not limited in its particular use as a covering for a window or door, and may be used in any application as a partition, shade, and/or the like, relative to and/or within any type of architectural structure.

(17) As shown in the illustrated embodiment, when suspended by the support structure **106** relative to an architectural structure **102**, the panel assembly **104** may be moveable horizontally or laterally between an extended position (FIG. **1**) and a retracted position (FIG. **2**). When extended, the panel assembly **104** may be configured to extend across and at least partially cover the adjacent architectural structure **102**. For example, the panel assembly **104** may be configured to extend in a heightwise or vertical direction (indicated by arrow V shown in FIGS. **1-3**) between a top end **110** and a bottom end **112** and in a horizontal or lateral direction (indicated by arrow L in FIGS. **1-3**) between a first lateral end **114** and a second lateral end **116**. When retracted, the panel assembly **104** may generally be configured to be collapsed in the lateral direction L to allow the blind **100** to be positioned along one side of the adjacent architectural structure **102**, thereby exposing at least a portion of the architectural structure **102**. It should be appreciated that the lateral movement of the panel assembly **104** relative to the architectural structure **102** may be achieved, for example, by sliding the hangers **108** along the associated laterally extending track **107** of the support structure **106**.

(18) In several embodiments, the panel assembly **104** is formed from a plurality of individual panels **120** (e.g., fabric panels) configured to be coupled together in a side-by-side arrangement along the lateral direction L of the blind **100**. As particularly shown in FIG. **1**, each panel **120** generally extends in the vertical direction V between a top panel end **122** and a bottom panel end **124**, with the top ends **122** of the panels **120** configured to be positioned adjacent to the track **107** of the support structure **106** when suspended relative thereto (e.g., via the hangers **108** and connector clips **202**). In several embodiments, each panel **120** may be configured to define a curved or U-shaped cross-sectional profile when suspended relative to the support structure **106** in an extended, opened state (e.g., as shown in FIG. **1**—see also FIGS. **7-10**). For instance, as particularly shown in FIG. **1**, each panel **120** may include a front wall **126** (also referred to herein as the light-transmitting portion or panel section of each panel **120**) that defines a curved or arcuate profile (e.g., when in the extended, opened state) and extends in the lateral direction L between opposed first and second lateral sidewalls **128**, **130** of the panel **120** (also referred to herein as the light-blocking portions or panel sections of each panel **120**), with the various walls **126**, **128**, **130** extending in the vertical direction V between the top and bottom ends **122**, **124** of the panel **120**. Additionally, each panel **120** may extend in a depthwise direction (indicated by arrow D in FIGS. **1-3**) between a front side **132** and a rear side **134**, with the front sides **132** of the respective panels **120** being generally configured to be positioned along a front face **111** of the panel assembly **104** while the rear sides **134** of the respective panels **120** being generally configured to be positioned along a rear face **113** of the panel assembly **104**.

(19) It should be appreciated that the terms “front” and rear” are generally used herein simply to distinguish opposite sides or faces of the blind **100**, itself, and/or opposite sides or faces of components or features of the blind **100**. For purposes of description, the front face **111** of the panel assembly **104** (along with the front sides **132** of the panels **120**) will be described herein as being positioned along the side of the blind **100** facing towards the interior of the room within which the blind **100** is installed, with the rear face **113** of the panel assembly **104** (along with the rear sides **134** of the panels **120**) facing towards the adjacent architectural structure **102**. However, in general, one of ordinary skill in the art should readily appreciate that the front face **111** of the panel assembly **104** may generally be configured to face in either direction relative to the interior of the room.

(20) In addition to being extended and retracted in the lateral direction L to selectively expose/cover the adjacent architectural structure **102**, the panel assembly **104** may also be configured to be adjusted between opened and closed states. Specifically, the various panels **120** may be configured to be rotated or tilted (e.g., via the associated hangers **108**) between an opened state (e.g., as shown in FIG. 1), at which the lateral sidewalls **128**, **130** of the various panels **120** are generally oriented substantially parallel to the depthwise direction D of the blind **100**, with the front walls **126** of the panels **120** generally defining the front face **111** of the panel assembly **104**, and a closed state (e.g., as shown in FIG. 3), at which the lateral sidewalls **128**, **130** of the various panels **120** are tilted relative to the depthwise direction D into an overlapping configuration such that adjacent sidewalls **128**, **130** of the panels **120** overlap each other along the lateral direction L of the blind **100**. In this regard, by carefully selecting the light-blocking/transmitting properties of the various walls **126**, **128**, **130** of the panels **120**, such tilting of the panel assembly **104** permits the blind **100** to be transitioned between different light-blocking/transmitting states. For example, in several embodiments, the lateral sidewalls **128**, **130** of each panel **120** may have a light-blocking configuration (e.g., by being formed from a light-blocking or room-darkening material), while the front wall **126** of each panel **120** may have a light-transmitting configuration (e.g., by being formed entirely or substantially from a light-filtering or light-transmitting material). In such embodiments, when the panel assembly **104** is moved to the opened state, light may be allowed to pass between the non-tilted (relative to the depthwise direction D), non-overlapping lateral sidewalls **128**, **130** of each panel **120** and through the front face **111** of the panel assembly **104** defined by the light-transmitting portion of each panel **120** (i.e., the front wall **126** of each panel **120**), thereby providing an opened, light-transmitting position/state for the blind **100**. In contrast, when the panel assembly **104** is moved to the closed state, the light-blocking portions of the panels **120** (i.e., the lateral sidewalls **128**, **130** of the panels **120**) are placed in an overlapping configuration such that the panels **120** function to block or substantially block light from passing through the panel assembly **104**, thereby providing a closed, light-blocking position/state for the blind **100**. It should be appreciated that above-described tilting of the panel assembly **104** may be achieved, for example, by rotating the various hangers **108** relative to the associated track **107** of the support structure **106** about respective tilt axes using any suitable tilting mechanism or system known in the art (e.g., suitable tilt mechanisms/systems conventionally used with vertical blinds).

(21) As indicated above, the blind **100** also includes connector clips **202** for coupling the panel assembly **104** to the track **107** of the support structure **106** (e.g., via the hangers **108**). Specifically, in several embodiments, each panel **120** defines first and second pockets **140**, **142** (FIG. 1) (also referred to herein as right-side and left-side pockets **140**, **142** for ease of discussion) at its top end **122** for receiving respective connector clips **202** (also referred to herein as right-side and left-side clips **202** for ease of discussion). In such embodiments, by coupling the connector clips **202** of each panel **120** to corresponding hangers **108**, the panels **120** (and, thus, the panel assembly **104**) may be suspended relative to the track **107**.

(22) Additionally, the connector clips **202** may also function to connect or couple adjacent panels **120** together in a side-by-side arrangement along the top end **110** of the panel assembly **104**. Specifically, as will be described in greater detail below, pairs of connector clips **202** (e.g., each including a left-side clip and a right-side clip) may form a clip assembly used to couple adjacent panels **120** to each other. For instance, the left-side clip **202** of a first clip assembly installed within the left-side pocket **142** of a first panel **120** may be configured to be coupled to the right-side clip **202** of the first clip assembly installed within the right-side pocket **140** of an adjacent second panel **120**, thereby coupling the top ends **122** of the first and second panels **120** together along the adjacent sides of the panels **120** (and also allowing a single hanger **108** to be used to support such adjacent sides of the panels **120** relative to the track **107**). Similarly, with reference to the same example, the right-side clip **202** of a second clip assembly installed within the right-side pocket **140** of the first panel **120** may be configured to be coupled to the left-side clip **202** of the second clip



assembly installed within the left-side pocket **142** of an adjacent third panel **120** (e.g., disposed along the opposed side of the first panel **120** from the second panel **120**), thereby coupling the top ends **122** of the first and third panels **120** together along the adjacent sides of the panels **120** (and also allowing a single hanger **108** to be used to support such adjacent sides of the panels **120** relative to the track **107**).

(23) It should be appreciated that, by configuring the connector clips **202** to be received within pockets **140**, **142** defined or formed in the panels **120**, the clips **202** can be entirely or substantially hidden from view when the various panels **120** are assembled together to form the panel assembly **104**. Additionally, the pocket-based configuration also facilitates dropping or lowering the connection provided between the clips **202** and the hangers **108** of the support structure **106** to a position below the top end **110** of the panel assembly **104** (and, thus, the top ends **122** of the individual panels **120**). As a result, the top end **110** of the panel assembly **104** may be positioned directly adjacent to the track **107** of the support structure, thereby eliminating (or at least minimizing) light gaps between the panel assembly **104** and the track **107**.

(24) Referring now to FIG. 4, a schematic view of the top end **122** of one of the panels **120** described above is illustrated in accordance with aspects of the present subject matter, particularly illustrating the panel **120** in a flattened or planar state for purposes of illustration. As indicated above, each panel **120** may include walls **126**, **128**, **130** having different light-blocking/transmitting characteristics or properties to provide the desired light-transmitting/blocking configuration(s) when transitioning the panel assembly **104** between its opened and closed states. Specifically, in several embodiments, the front wall **126** of each panel **120** may correspond to the light-transmitting portion or panel section of the panel **120** and, thus, may have a light-transmitting configuration (e.g., by being formed entirely or substantially from a light-filtering or light-transmitting material, such as a fabric having light-transmitting characteristics or a clear or transparent film material). In such embodiments, the lateral sidewalls **128**, **130** of each panel **120** may correspond to the light-blocking portions of the panel **120** and, thus may have a light-blocking configuration (e.g., by being formed from a light-blocking material, such as a room-darkening material or a fabric having light-blocking characteristics). For instance, in one embodiment, the front wall **126** of each panel **120** may be formed from a sheer material while the lateral sidewalls **128**, **130** of each panel **120** may be formed from a blackout or room-darkening material.

(25) It should be appreciated that, in several embodiments, the various walls **126**, **128**, **130** of each panel **120** may correspond to separate panel strips (e.g., elongated, rectangular-shaped strips of material) that are configured to be assembled together to form the panel **120**. In such embodiments, the separate strips of material may be connected to each other using any suitable connection means/process, such as by sewing, welding, gluing, taping, etc., the material strips together at each interface **148** defined between the strips. In one embodiment, each separate strip of material may be formed from a fabric (e.g., a woven or non-woven fabric), a film material, polymer material, and/or the like. Alternatively, the various walls **126**, **128**, **130** of each panel **120** may be formed integrally with one another. For instance, in one embodiment, each panel **120** may be formed from an integral weaving process during which the front wall **126** and lateral sidewalls **128**, **130** are woven together as a single, continuously woven component. In such an embodiment, one or more weave characteristics (e.g., the weave pattern, weave density, and/or the like) may be altered between the front wall **126** and lateral sidewalls **128**, **130** to provide the desired light-transmitting/blocking characteristics for each wall/portion of the panel **120**.

(26) Additionally, as indicated above, each panel **120** may include first and second pockets **140**, **142** at its top end **122** for receiving a corresponding pair of connector clips **202** (FIG. 1). In one embodiment, the pockets **140**, **142** may be formed by folding a lateral panel section **150** of the panel **120** over at the top end **122** and securing the folded panel section **150** along a seam or connection line (e.g., as indicated by line **152** in FIG. 4), such as by sewing, welding, gluing, taping, etc. the folded panel section **150** along the connection line **152**. In such an embodiment, the

first and second pockets **140**, **142** may correspond to portions of a continuous pass-through channel **154** extending laterally across the panel **120** between opposed first and second open ends **156**, **158** of the channel **154** and vertically between the top end **122** of the panel **120** and the connection line **152** at which the folded lateral section **150** is connected to the remainder of the panel **120**. For example, as shown in FIG. 4, the first and second pockets **140**, **142** generally correspond to the lateral portions of the continuous channel **154** that extend across the first and second lateral sidewalls **128**, **130** of the panel **120**. Specifically, in the illustrated embodiment, the first pocket **140** extends laterally between the first open end **156** of the channel **154** defined at an edge **160** of the first lateral sidewall **128** and the interface **148** defined between the first lateral sidewall **128** and the front wall **126**. Similarly, the second pocket **142** extends laterally between the second open end **158** of the channel **154** defined at an edge **162** of the second lateral sidewall **130** and the interface **148** defined between the second lateral sidewall **130** and the front wall **126**. It should be appreciated that, in other embodiments, the first and second pockets **140**, **142** may be formed in any other suitable manner and/or may correspond to discrete or separate pockets positioned at the top end **122** of the panel **120**. For instance, in another embodiment, the first and second pockets **140**, **142** may be formed as separate pockets that are isolated from each other, such as by providing vertically extending seam or connection line(s) between the pockets **140**, **142** to separate one from the other across the top end **122** of the panel **120**.

(27) Additionally, as shown in FIG. 4, the panel **120** also includes cut-out sections or access windows **164**, **166** defined or formed at the top end **122** of the panel **120**. Specifically, a first access window **164** is defined through a portion of the first pocket **140** at the top end **122** of the first lateral sidewall **128** of the panel **120** to provide access to the interior of such pocket **140**, while a second access window **166** is defined through a portion of the second pocket **142** at the top end **122** of the second lateral sidewall **130** of the panel **120** to provide access to the interior of such pocket **142**. As will be described below, a width **168** of each access window **164**, **166** may be selected to provide access to or otherwise expose suitable structure of the connector clips **202** (e.g., when installed within the associated pockets **140**, **142** of the panels **120**) to facilitate, for example,: (1) coupling adjacent connector clips **202** (and, thus, the adjacent panels **120**) to each other; (2) retaining the connector clips **202** relative to the adjacent panels **120**; and/or (3) coupling the connector clips **202** to the hangers **108** for suspending the panels **120** relative to the track **107** of the support structure **106**.

(28) Moreover, in several embodiments, a stiffening member may be provided at one or more locations along the height of each panel **120** to provide additional stiffness to the panel **120**, which can assist in maintaining the U-shaped cross-sectional profile of the panels **120** when installed relative to the support structure **106**. For instance, as shown in FIG. 4, a stiffening member **170** has been installed at or adjacent to the top end **122** of the panel **120** (e.g., directly below the pockets **140**, **142**) that extends laterally across the panel **120**. A similar stiffening member **170** may also be installed, for example, at or adjacent to the bottom end **124** of the panel **120** and/or at one or more other locations between the top and bottom ends **122**, **124** of the panel **120**. For instance, in the example embodiment shown in FIG. 1, each panel **120** is shown as including stiffening members **170** (indicated by dashed lines) located adjacent to both their top and bottom ends **122**, **124**. In one embodiment, each stiffening member **170** may comprise a stiffening tape applied laterally across the various walls **126**, **128**, **130** of the panel **120** (e.g., via a heat press). In such an embodiment, the stiffening tape may provide additional stiffness or rigidity to the panel **120** while still being sufficiently flexible to allow the panel **120** to be formed into its U-shaped cross-sectional profile.

(29) Referring now to FIGS. 5 and 6, perspective views of one embodiment of a clip assembly **200** suitable for coupling adjacent panels of a vertical curtain blind to each other and/or for coupling such panels to corresponding mounting hardware configured to suspend the blind relative to associated support structure are illustrated in accordance with aspects of the present subject matter. For purposes of discussion, the illustrated clip assembly **200** will be described with reference to the

vertical curtain blind **100** and related panels **120** and described above with reference to FIGS. **1-4**. However, it should be appreciated that, in other embodiments, the clip assembly **200** may be utilized with blinds having any other suitable configuration and/or with panels having any other suitable panel configuration.

(30) As shown in FIGS. **5** and **6**, the clip assembly **200** includes a pair of connector clips **202**, namely a first connector clip **202A** and a second connector clip **202B**. In general, each of the connector clips **202A**, **202B** includes an elongated clip body **204**. As shown in the illustrated embodiment, each clip body **204** is generally configured as a rectangular-shaped, plate-like object extending in a lengthwise direction (indicated by arrow **206** in FIGS. **5** and **6**) between a first end **208** and a second end **210** of the connector clip **202A**, **202B** and in a crosswise direction (indicated by arrow **212** in FIGS. **5** and **6**) between a first face **214** and a second face **216** of the clip **202A**, **202B**. Additionally, the body **204** of each connector clip **202A**, **202B** extends in a heightwise direction (indicated by arrow **218** in FIGS. **5** and **6**) between a top side **220** and a bottom side **222** of the clip **202A**, **202B**. In several embodiments, each clip body **204** is dimensionally configured (e.g., in the lengthwise, crosswise, and heightwise directions **206**, **212**, **218**) to allow the associated connector clip **202A**, **202B** to be received within a corresponding pocket of a panel. For example, as will be described in greater detail below, when coupling adjacent first and second panels **120** to each other, the first connector clip **202A** may be received within one of the pockets of the first panel **120** (e.g., the left-side or right-side pocket of the first panel **120**), while the second connector clip **202B** may be received within the pocket of the second panel positioned adjacent to the pocket of the first panel within which the first connector clip **202A** is installed.

(31) Moreover, each connector clip **202A**, **202B** includes connection structure for allowing the clips **202A**, **202B** to be removably coupled to each other. For instance, in the illustrated embodiment, the connector clips **202A**, **202B** include male/female connection structure for securing the clips **202A**, **202B** together. Specifically, as shown in FIG. **5**, the first connector clip **202A** includes fastener channels or openings **224** defined through its body **204** between the outer faces **214**, **216** of the clip **202A** that are configured to receive corresponding fastener arms **226** extending outwardly from the adjacent outer face of the second connector clip **202B** (e.g., the first outer face **214** of the clip **202B**). In such an embodiment, by aligning the fastener arms **226** of the second connector clip **202B** with the fastener openings **224** defined by the first connector clip **202A** and pressing the connector clips **202A**, **202B** together (e.g., in the crosswise direction **212**), the arms **226** may be received within and extend through the openings **224** (e.g., as shown in FIG. **6**) to couple the first connector clip **202A** to the second connector clip **202B**. As shown in FIG. **6**, once coupled together, a connection interface **227** is defined between the connector clips **202A**, **202B** between the adjacent outer faces of the clips **202A**, **202B** (e.g., the second outer face **216** of the first clip **202A** and the first outer face **214** of the second clip **202B**), with the fastener arms **226** extending across the connection interface **227** in the crosswise direction **212**.

(32) In one embodiment, the fastener arms **226** may correspond to hook-like members or may otherwise include engagement features for engaging the adjacent face of the opposed connector clip upon being inserted through the fastener openings **224**. For instance, as shown in FIG. **6**, each fastener arm **226** of the second connector clip **202B** includes an engagement flange **228** that overlaps the outer edges of the respective fastener openings **224** and engages the adjacent outer face **214** of the first connector clip **202A** when the arms **226** are inserted sufficiently through the openings **224**, thereby locking or otherwise securing the connector clips **202A**, **202B** together. Additionally, in one embodiment, a longitudinal spacing **230** (FIG. **5**) defined between the ends of the engagement flanges **228** of the fastener arms **226** may be slightly larger than a corresponding longitudinal spacing **232** (FIG. **5**) defined between the outer sides of the fastener openings **224**, thereby requiring the fastener arms **226** to bow or flex inwardly towards each other as the arms **226** are inserted through the openings **224**. As a result, the fastener arms **226** may subsequently snap-back outwardly away from each other once the engagement flanges **228** are inserted fully through

the openings **224**. In such an embodiment, to decouple the connector clips **202A**, **202B**, the fastener arms **226** may be pressed inwardly towards each other until the engagement flanges **228** clear the adjacent outer face **214** of the first connector clip **202A**, at which point the arms **226** may be slid outwardly through the fastener openings **224** as the connector clips **202A**, **202B** are separated from each other (e.g., in the crosswise direction **212**).

(33) It should be appreciated that, in one embodiment, the longitudinal spacing **230**, **232** defined between the fastener openings/arms **224**, **226** may generally be selected to be less than the widths **168** (FIG. **4**) of the access windows **164**, **166** defined in the pockets **140**, **142** within which the connector clips **202A**, **202B** are installed. As such, when using the connector clips **202A**, **202B** to couple adjacent panels **120** to each other, the connector clips **202A**, **202B** may be inserted within the respective pockets **140**, **142** of the adjacent panels **120** such that the fastener openings **224** of the first connector clip **202A** are generally aligned with the access window of its associated pocket (and, thus, are accessible along the exterior of the pocket) and the fastener arms **226** of the second connector clip **202B** extend through and project outwardly relative to the access window of its associated pocket, thereby allowing the arms **226** to be inserted through the openings **224** as the panels **120** are brought into abutting engagement or otherwise pushed together at their top ends **122**.

(34) In other embodiments, the interlocking male/female connection structure described above may be provided in any other suitable arrangement. For instance, in one embodiment, the fastener openings **224** may be defined through the body **204** of the second connector clip **202B**, with the fastener arms **226** extending outwardly from the first connector clip **202A** for receipt within the openings **224**. Alternatively, each connector clip **202A**, **202B** may be configured to include both male/female connection features. For instance, as will be described below with reference to the embodiment shown in FIG. **11**, one of the fastener openings **224** of the first connector clip **202A** may be replaced with a fastener arm **226** configured to extend outwardly from the first connector clip **202A**. In such an embodiment, one of the fastener arms **226** of the second connector clip **202B** may be replaced with a fastener opening **224** configured to receive the corresponding fastener arm **226** of the first connector clip **202A**.

(35) It should also be appreciated that, as an alternative to the male/female connection structure described above, the connector clips **202A**, **202B** may include any other suitable connection structure that allows the clips **202A**, **202B** to be coupled together. For instance, in other embodiments, buttons, snaps, magnets, hook-and-loop fasteners, and/or other suitable mechanical fasteners may be used as connection structure for coupling the connector clips **202A**, **202B** to each other.

(36) Referring still to FIGS. **5** and **6**, one or both of the connector clips **202A**, **202B** may include mounting structure for coupling the clip assembly **200** to a corresponding hanger **108** or any other suitable mounting hardware used to suspend the panel assembly **104** relative to the track **107** of the associated support structure **106**. For instance, as shown in the illustrated embodiment, the first connector clip **202A** includes a mounting port **234** defined through its clip body **204** between the first and second outer faces **214**, **216** of the clip **202A** that is spaced vertically apart from the top side **220** of the clip **202A**. Additionally, as particularly shown in FIG. **5**, the second connector clip **202B** includes a mounting channel **236** defined through its clip body **204** between the first and second outer faces **214**, **216** of the clip **202B** that is open along the top side **220** of the clip **202B**. In such an embodiment, when the connector clips **202A**, **202B** are coupled together (e.g., via the corresponding connection structure), the mounting channel **236** of the second connector clip **202B** may generally be aligned with the mounting port **234** of the first connector clip **202A** (e.g., in the crosswise direction **212**) to allow a portion of the corresponding hanger **108** of the support structure **106** (e.g., a hooked end **109** of the hanger **108** as shown in the dashed lines of FIG. **6**) to be inserted through both the mounting channel **236** and mounting port **234** to couple the clip assembly **200** to the support structure **106**. In such an embodiment, the hanger **108** may directly engage the portion

of the first connector clip **202A** extending above the mounting port **234** (e.g., a connection bridge **238** of the clip body **204**) to vertically support the first connector clip **202A** (and, thus, the second connector clip **202B** by way of its connection to the first clip **202A**) relative to the associated support structure **106**.

(37) It should be appreciated that the longitudinal positioning of the mounting structure relative to the longitudinal ends **208**, **210** of each clip **202A**, **202B** may generally be selected to ensure that the mounting structure is aligned with the access windows **164**, **166** (FIG. 4) defined in the respective pockets **140**, **142** within which the clips **202A**, **202B** are installed when the clips **202A**, **202B** are coupled to each other (e.g., via the connection structure). For instance, as shown in FIG. 5, the mounting port **234** of the first connector clip **202A** and the mounting channel **236** of the second connector clip **202B** are each positioned between the connection structure of the respective clip **202A**, **202B** in the longitudinal direction **206**. As such, upon coupling the connector clips **202A**, **202B** together (e.g., as installed within the pockets of adjacent panels), it can be ensured that the mounting structure is aligned with the access windows **164**, **166** of the pockets **140**, **142** when subsequently securing the clip assembly **200** to a corresponding hanger **108** for suspending the panels **120** relative to the associated support structure **106**.

(38) It should be appreciated that, in other embodiments, any other suitable mounting structure and/or configuration may be used to couple the clip assembly **200** to the mounting hardware (e.g., hangers **108**) used to suspend the panel assembly **104** relative to the track **107** of the support structure **106**. For instance, in one alternative embodiment, the first connector clip **202A** may define the open-ended mounting channel **236**, while the second connector clip **202B** defines the closed-off mounting port **234**. In another alternative embodiment, the first and second connector clips **202A**, **202B** may both define a closed-off mounting port **234** (e.g., as shown in the embodiment of FIG. 11), thereby providing a direct connection between the hanger **108** and each connector clip **202A**, **202B**.

(39) Moreover, in several embodiments, one or both of the connector clips **202A**, **202B** may also include separate retention structure extending outwardly from an outer face of the clip **202A**, **202B** opposite the connection interface **227** defined between the clips **202A**, **202B**, with the retention structure generally being configured to retain the clip(s) **202A**, **202B** relative to the pocket(s) of the panel(s) within which the clip(s) **202A**, **202B** is installed. For instance, as shown in FIGS. 5 and 6, the first connector clip **202A** includes first and second retention members **240**, **242** (e.g., in the form of retention flanges or hooks) that extend outwardly from the first outer face **214** of the clip **202A**. As a result, when the clips **202A**, **202B** are coupled together, the retention members **240**, **242** project outwardly away from (and are positioned on the opposite side of the clip **202A** relative to) the connection interface **227** defined between the clips **202A**, **202B**.

(40) In one embodiment, the retention members **240**, **242** are longitudinally positioned along the first outer face **214** of the clip **202A** between the clip's opposed ends **208**, **210** such that, when the clip **202A** is installed within a pocket of a given panel, the retention members **240**, **242** extend through the access window of the pocket and engage the outer edges of the window. Specifically, in one embodiment, a longitudinal distance **244** defined between the outer ends of the hooked retention members **240**, **242** may be selected to be slightly greater than the width **168** (FIG. 4) of the access windows **164**, **166** defined in the pockets **140**, **142**, with a longitudinal distance **246** defined between inner sections of the hooked retention members **240**, **242** being selected to be slightly smaller than the width **168** of the access windows **164**, **166**. As such, when installing the connector clip **202A** within a pocket of a given panel, the retention members **240**, **242** may be inserted through the respective access window and hook around the outer edges of the window to maintain the relative positioning of the connector clip **202A** within the pocket.

(41) Additionally, in one embodiment, the longitudinal distance or gap **244** defined between the outer ends of the hooked retention members **240**, **242** may also form a longitudinal retention zone **245** (FIG. 6) of the clip assembly **200** within which the separate connection structure and mounting

structure of the connector clips **202A**, **202B** is positioned. Specifically, as shown in FIG. 6, the connection structure of each clip **202A**, **202B** (e.g., the fastener openings/arms **224**, **226**) is positioned entirely between the outer ends of the hooked retention members **240**, **242** in the longitudinal direction **206** and, thus, is positioned within the longitudinal retention zone **245** of the clip assembly **200**. Similarly, the mounting structure of each clips **202A**, **202B** (e.g., the mounting port **234** and mounting channel **236**) is positioned entirely between the outer ends of the hooked retention members **240**, **242** in the longitudinal direction **206** and, thus, is positioned within the longitudinal retention zone **245** of the clip assembly **200**. As indicated above, the mounting structure of each clip **202A**, **202B** is also positioned entirely between the correspond connection structure of each respective clip **202A**, **202B** in the longitudinal direction **206**.

(42) It should be appreciated that, although not shown, the second connector clip **202B** may also include separate retention structure for retaining the clip **202B** relative to the pocket of the panel within which the clip **202B** is installed. For instance, similar to the first connector clip **202A**, the second connector clip **202B** may include first and second retention members **240**, **242** (e.g., in the form of retention flanges or hooks) that project outwardly from the outer face of the clip **202B** opposite the connection interface **227** (e.g., the second outer face **216** of the clips **202B**). In such an embodiment, the retention members **240**, **242** of the second clip **202B** may be configured to extend through an adjacent access window and hook around the outer edges of the window to retain the clip **202B** relative to the associated pocket. As an alternative to including separate retention structure, it should be appreciated that the connection structure of the second connector clip **202B** may also function as retention structure for such clip **202B**. For example, the fastener arms **226** may function to limit longitudinal travel of the second connector clip **202B** within its associated pocket as the arms **226** contact against or otherwise engage the outer edges of the respective access window.

(43) Additionally, it should be appreciated that, in several embodiments, the connector clips **202A**, **202B** may also include a visual indicator(s) for identifying the proper orientation and/or installation direction when installing the clips **202A**, **202B** within their associated pockets. For instance, as shown in FIG. 5, the second connector clip **202B** includes a label **248** identifying the top side **220** of the clip **202B** as well as an arrow **250** identifying the direction in which the clip **202B** is to be installed within an associated pocket. Although not shown, the first connector clip **202A** may include similar visual indicators to identify the clip's proper orientation and/or installation direction.

(44) A process or method for coupling adjacent panels of a vertical curtain blind together will now be described with reference to FIGS. 7-9. In general, the method will be described with reference to the vertical curtain blind **100** and related panels **120** and connector clips **202** described above with reference to FIGS. 1-6. However, it should be appreciated that, in other embodiments, the disclosed method may be utilized with blinds having any other suitable configuration, with panels having any other suitable panel configuration, and/or connector clips having any other suitable configuration. It should also be appreciated that, for purposes of discussion, the first connector clip **202A** of the above-described clip assembly **200** will generally be described herein as corresponding to the “right-side connector clip” configured to be inserted within the first or right-side pocket **140** of a panel **120**, while the second connector clip **202B** of the above-described clip assembly **200** will generally be described herein as corresponding to the “left-side connector clip” configured to be inserted within the second or left-side pocket **142** of an adjacent panel **120**. However, in other embodiments, the installation configuration may be reversed, with the first connector clip **202A** being inserted within the second or left-side pocket **142** of a panel **120** and the second connector clip **202B** being inserted within the first or right-side pocket **140** of an adjacent panel **120**.

(45) Referring to FIGS. 7-9, the upper portions of two adjacent panels **120** (e.g., a first panel **120A** and a second panel **120B**) forming a portion of a panel assembly **104** are illustrated for purposes of describing the disclosed method. In general, the panels **120A**, **120B** are configured the same as the

panel **120** described above with reference to FIG. 4. For instance, each panel **120A**, **120B** includes a light-transmitting front wall **126** and first and second light-blocking sidewalls, **128**, **130**, with a first or right-side pocket **140** being formed at the top end **122** of each panel **120A**, **120B** along the first sidewall **128** and a second or left-side pocket **142** formed at the top end **122** of each panel **120A**, **120B** along the second sidewall **130**. As particularly shown in FIG. 7, to couple the first and second panels **120A**, **120B** together, the connector clips **202A**, **202B** of a given clip assembly **200** are initially installed into the adjacent pockets **140**, **142** of the panels **120A**, **120B**. For instance, in the illustrated embodiment, the first connector clip **202A** is being installed within the right-side pocket **140** of the first panel **120A** while the second connector clip **202B** is being installed within the left-side pocket **142** of the second panel **120B**, thereby allowing the panels **120A**, **120B** to be coupled together at their top ends **122** in a side-by-side arrangement in which the first lateral sidewall **128** of the first panel **120A** will generally extend adjacent to the second lateral sidewall **130** of the second panel **120B** when the panels **120A**, **120B** are subsequently suspended from the associated support structure **106** of the blind **100** as part of the overall panel assembly **104**.

(46) As particularly shown in the transition from FIG. 7 to FIG. 8, the connector clips **202A**, **202B** are configured to be inserted into the pockets **140**, **142** until the mounting/connection/retention structure of each clip **202A**, **202B** is generally aligned with the adjacent access window **164**, **166** of its respective pocket **140**, **142**. For instance, as shown in FIG. 8, the first connector clip **202A** may be configured to be positioned within its respective pocket **140** such that the retention structure of the clip **202A** (e.g., the first and second hooked retention members **240**, **242**) extends through and projects outwardly from the access window **164** of such pocket **140**, thereby allowing the retention members **240**, **242** to engage the edges of the access window **164** and maintain the first connector clip **202A** at the desired position within the pocket **140**. Similarly, as shown in FIG. 8, the second connector clip **202B** may be configured to be positioned within its respective pocket **142** such that the connection structure of the clip **202B** (e.g., the fastener arms **226**) extends through and projects outwardly from the access window **166** of such pocket **142**. Additionally, as shown in FIG. 8, when the connector clips **202A**, **202B** are installed within their respective pockets **140**, **142**, the mounting/connection/retention structure of each clip **202A**, **202B** is generally positioned below the top end **122** of its corresponding panel **120A**, **120B**.

(47) Upon properly positioning the connector clips **202A**, **202B** within their respective pockets **140**, **142**, the adjacent lateral sidewalls **128**, **130** of the panels **120A**, **120B** may then be moved towards each other to allow the connector clips **202A**, **202B** to be coupled together (thus coupling the top end **122** of the first panel **120A** to the top end **122** of the second panel **120B**). For instance, as particularly shown in the transition from FIG. 8 to FIG. 9, by moving the panels **120A**, **120B** towards one another in a side-by-side arrangement, the fastener arms **226** of the second connector clip **202B** may be received within and pushed through the fastener openings **224** of the first connector clip **202A** until the engagement flanges **228** of the arms **226** snap outwardly to engage the adjacent outer face of the first connector clip **202A**, thereby coupling the clips **202A**, **202B** together. The panels may then be separately coupled to the corresponding mounting hardware of the support structure **106** (e.g., via the mounting structure of the connector clips **202A**, **202B**) to suspend the panels **120A**, **120B** relative thereto. For instance, as described above with reference to FIG. 6, a hooked end **109** of one of the hangers **108** may be inserted through the aligned mounting channel **236** and mounting port **234** of the connector clips **202A**, **202B** in order to suspend the panels **120A**, **120B** relative to the track **107** of the support structure **106**.

(48) It should be appreciated that, by positioning the connector clips **202A**, **202B** in their respective pockets **140**, **142** in the manner described above, the clips **202A**, **202B** may be substantially or entirely concealed or otherwise hidden from view. For instance, as shown in FIG. 9, with the panels **120A**, **120B** coupled together, the connector clips **202A**, **202B** should not be visible along the front face **111** of the associated panel assembly **104**. Moreover, by positioning the associated mounting structure of the connector clips **202A**, **202B** below the top ends **122** of the panels **120A**, **120B**, the

connection between the panels **120A**, **120B** and the associated hanger **108** is similarly positioned below the top ends **122** of the panels **120A**, **120B**. As a result, the top end **110** of the associated panel assembly **104** can be positioned directly adjacent to the track **107** of the support structure when suspended therefrom via the hangers **108**, thereby eliminating or minimizing lights gaps between the track **107** and the panel assembly **104**.

(49) Referring now to FIG. **10**, a top view of three adjacent panels **120A**, **120B**, **120C** assembled together in a side-by-side arrangement in a manner consistent with the above-described panel-connection method is illustrated in accordance with aspects of the present subject matter. As shown in FIG. **10**, first and second clip assemblies **200A**, **200B** are used to couple a given panel (e.g., central panel **120A**) to two adjacent panels (e.g., a first adjacent panel **120B** and a second adjacent panel **120C**). Specifically, as shown, the first clip assembly **200A** includes a first connector clip **202A** installed within the right-side pocket **140** of the central panel **120A** and a second connector clip **202B** installed within the left-side pocket **142** of the first adjacent panel **120B**, thereby allowing central panel **120A** to be coupled to the first adjacent panel **120B**. Similarly, the second clip assembly **200B** includes a first connector clip **202A** installed within the right-side pocket **140** of the second adjacent panel **120C** and a second connector clip **202B** installed within the left-side pocket **142** of the central panel **120A**, thereby allowing central panel **120A** to be coupled to the second adjacent panel **120C**. As indicated above, upon coupling the adjacent panels **120A**, **120B**, **120C** together, the panels may be suspended from the track **107** of the support structure **106** by coupling the corresponding mounting hardware to the mounting structure of each clip assembly **200A**, **200B**. For instance, a first hanger **108** may be coupled to the mounting structure of the first clip assembly **200A** to vertically support the adjacent sides of the central panel **120A** and the first adjacent panel **120B** relative to the support structure **106**. Similarly, a second hanger **108** may be coupled to the mounting structure of the second clip assembly **200B** to vertically support the adjacent sides of the central panel **120A** and the second adjacent panel **120C** relative to the support structure **106**.

(50) It should be appreciated that, although FIG. **10** only shows three panels **120** coupled together in a side-by-side arrangement, any suitable number of panels **120** may be coupled together to form a panel assembly **104** in accordance with aspects of the present subject matter. In particular, the specific number of panels **120** used to form the panel assembly **104** may generally vary, for example, based on the lateral width of the architectural structure **102** relative to which the associated blind **100** is to be installed.

(51) Additionally, it should be appreciated that, in the embodiments of the clip assemblies **200** described above with reference to FIGS. **5-10**, the first and second connector clips **202A**, **202B** of each clip assembly **200** have different configurations (e.g., differences between the connection/mounting/retention structure of the clips **202A**, **202B**). However, in other embodiments, the connector clips **202** of each clip assembly **200** may, instead, have the same configuration. For instance, FIG. **11** illustrates a perspective, exploded view of a clip assembly **200** in which the first and second connector clips **202A**, **202B** have the exact same configuration or are otherwise identical. Specifically, as shown, both connector clips **202A**, **202B** have the same mounting structure (e.g., matching mounting ports **234**), the same connection structure (e.g., one fastener arm **226** and one fastener opening **224**), and the same retention structure (e.g., first and second hooked retention members **240**, **242**—although the retention members for the second connector clip **202B** are not shown in FIG. **11**). In such an embodiment, to couple the connector clips **202A**, **202B** together, one of the clips simply needs to be rotated 180 degrees relative to the other clip to allow the connection structure of the clips to be properly aligned. For instance, in the embodiment of FIG. **11**, the second connector clip **202B** has been flipped relative to the first connector clip **202A** to facilitate inserting the fastener arms **226** of each clip **202A**, **202B** within the corresponding fastener openings **224** of the opposed clip **202A**, **202B**. In such an embodiment, it should be appreciated that, given the vertical positioning of the retention structure of the connector clips



202A, 202B, the first and second retention members 240, 242 of the flipped second connector clip 202B will be located closer to the bottom side of the clip 202B (as opposed to being located closer to the top side as shown in FIG. 11 for the first connector clip 202A). However, in other embodiments, the retention structure may, instead, be centered on each clip 202A, 202B relative to the heightwise direction 218 such that the retention members 240, 242 are disposed at the same height regardless of which connector clip 202A, 202B is flipped to facilitate coupling the clips together.

(52) While the foregoing Detailed Description and drawings represent various embodiments, it will be understood that various additions, modifications, and substitutions may be made therein without departing from the spirit and scope of the present subject matter. Each example is provided by way of explanation without intent to limit the broad concepts of the present subject matter. In particular, it will be clear to those skilled in the art that principles of the present disclosure may be embodied in other forms, structures, arrangements, proportions, and with other elements, materials, and components, without departing from the spirit or essential characteristics thereof. For instance, features illustrated or described as part of one embodiment can be used with another embodiment to yield a still further embodiment. Thus, it is intended that the present subject matter covers such modifications and variations as come within the scope of the appended claims and their equivalents. One skilled in the art will appreciate that the disclosure may be used with many modifications of structure, arrangement, proportions, materials, and components and otherwise, used in the practice of the disclosure, which are particularly adapted to specific environments and operative requirements without departing from the principles of the present subject matter. For example, elements shown as integrally formed may be constructed of multiple parts or elements shown as multiple parts may be integrally formed, the operation of elements may be reversed or otherwise varied, the size or dimensions of the elements may be varied. The presently disclosed embodiments are therefore to be considered in all respects as illustrative and not restrictive, the scope of the present subject matter being indicated by the appended claims, and not limited to the foregoing description.

(53) In the foregoing Detailed Description, it will be appreciated that the phrases “at least one”, “one or more”, and “and/or”, as used herein, are open-ended expressions that are both conjunctive and disjunctive in operation. The term “a” or “an” element, as used herein, refers to one or more of that element. As such, the terms “a” (or “an”), “one or more” and “at least one” can be used interchangeably herein. All directional references (e.g., proximal, distal, upper, lower, upward, downward, left, right, lateral, longitudinal, front, rear, top, bottom, above, below, vertical, horizontal, crosswise, radial, axial, clockwise, counterclockwise, and/or the like) are only used for identification purposes to aid the reader's understanding of the present subject matter, and/or serve to distinguish regions of the associated elements from one another, and do not limit the associated element, particularly as to the position, orientation, or use of the present subject matter. Connection references (e.g., attached, coupled, connected, joined, secured, mounted and/or the like) are to be construed broadly and may include intermediate members between a collection of elements and relative movement between elements unless otherwise indicated. As such, connection references do not necessarily infer that two elements are directly connected and in fixed relation to each other. Identification references (e.g., primary, secondary, first, second, third, fourth, etc.) are not intended to connote importance or priority, but are used to distinguish one feature from another.

(54) All apparatuses and methods disclosed herein are examples of apparatuses and/or methods implemented in accordance with one or more principles of the present subject matter. These examples are not the only way to implement these principles but are merely examples. Thus, references to elements or structures or features in the drawings must be appreciated as references to examples of embodiments of the present subject matter, and should not be understood as limiting the disclosure to the specific elements, structures, or features illustrated. Other examples of manners of implementing the disclosed principles will occur to a person of ordinary skill in the art

upon reading this disclosure.

(55) This written description uses examples to disclose the present subject matter, including the best mode, and also to enable any person skilled in the art to practice the present subject matter, including making and using any devices or systems and performing any incorporated methods. The patentable scope of the present subject matter is defined by the claims, and may include other examples that occur to those skilled in the art. Such other examples are intended to be within the scope of the claims if they include structural elements that do not differ from the literal language of the claims, or if they include equivalent structural elements with insubstantial differences from the literal languages of the claims.

(56) The following claims are hereby incorporated into this Detailed Description by this reference, with each claim standing on its own as a separate embodiment of the present disclosure. In the claims, the term “comprises/comprising” does not exclude the presence of other elements or steps. Furthermore, although individually listed, a plurality of means, elements or method steps may be implemented by, e.g., a single unit or processor. Additionally, although individual features may be included in different claims, these may possibly advantageously be combined, and the inclusion in different claims does not imply that a combination of features is not feasible and/or advantageous. In addition, singular references do not exclude a plurality. The terms “a”, “an”, “first”, “second”, etc., do not preclude a plurality. Reference signs in the claims are provided merely as a clarifying example and shall not be construed as limiting the scope of the claims in any way.

## Claims

1. A vertical curtain blind, comprising: a panel assembly comprising a plurality of individual panels coupled together in a side-by-side arrangement, each panel extending in a vertical direction between a top end and a bottom end, each panel including first and second pockets positioned along first and second sides of the panel, respectively, adjacent to the top end of the panel; and a plurality of clip assemblies, each clip assembly being configured to couple a respective pair of adjacent panels of the plurality of panels together, each clip assembly including a first connector clip positioned within the first pocket of a first panel of the respective pair of adjacent panels and a second connector clip positioned within the second pocket of an adjacent second panel of the respective pair of adjacent panels, with the first connector clip configured to be coupled to the second connector clip; wherein: the first connector clip includes connection structure configured to engage corresponding connection structure of the second connector clip to couple the first and second connector clips together; a first access window is defined through the first pocket of the first panel at the top end of the first panel and a second access window is defined through the second pocket of the second panel at the top end of the second panel; and the connection structures of the first and second connector clips are positioned below the top ends of the first and second panels and are aligned with the first and second access windows.

2. The vertical curtain blind of claim 1, wherein: each of the first and second access windows defines a longitudinal width in a longitudinal direction of the clip assembly and each of the first and second access windows extends in a heightwise direction of the clip assembly between a bottom end and an open top end, with the open top end being aligned with the top end of the respective first panel or second panel; and the connection structure of the first and second panels are positioned below the open top ends of the first and second access windows and are aligned with the first and second access windows in the longitudinal direction.

3. The vertical curtain blind of claim 1, wherein the entirety of each of the first and second connector clips is positioned below the top ends of the first and second panels.

4. The vertical curtain blind of claim 1, wherein: at least one of the first connector clip or the second connector clip includes mounting structure configured to couple the clip assembly to a hanger for vertically suspending the panel assembly relative to support structure for the blind; and

the mounting structure is positioned below the top end of the first and second panels and is aligned with the first and second access windows.

5. The vertical curtain blind of claim 4, wherein: the mounting structure comprises a mounting port defined through the at least one of the first connector clip or the second connector clip; and a portion of the hanger is configured to extend through the mounting port and engage the at least one of the first connector clip or the second connector clip.

6. The vertical curtain blind of claim 5, wherein the mounting port is positioned between the connection structures of the first and second connector clips in a longitudinal direction of the clip assembly.

7. The vertical curtain blind of claim 5, wherein the portion of the hanger is configured to extend through the first and second access windows at a location below the top end of the first and second panels.

8. The vertical curtain blind of claim 1, wherein the connection structure of the first connector clip includes one of a male connection structure or a female connection structure and the connection structure of the second connector clip includes the other of the male connection structure or the female connection structure.

9. The vertical curtain blind of claim 8, wherein the male connection structure comprises a fastener arm and the female connection structure comprises a fastener opening configured to receive the fastener arm.

10. The vertical curtain blind of claim 9, wherein: the fastener arm extends outwardly from a body of the second connector clip and the fastener opening is defined through a body of the first connector clip; and the fastener arm further comprises an engagement flange configured to engage an adjacent face of the first connector clip when the fastener arm is inserted through the fastener opening.

11. The vertical curtain blind of claim 1, wherein: at least one of the first connector clip or the second connector clip includes retention structure separate from the connection structure that extends outwardly from an outer face of the at least one of the first connector clip or the second connector clip; and the retention structure is positioned below the top end of the first and second panels and is at least partially aligned with at least one of the first access window or the second access window.

12. The vertical curtain blind of claim 11, wherein: when the first and second connector clips are coupled together, a connection interface is defined between adjacent outer faces of the first and second connector clips; and the outer face is positioned opposite the connection interface defined between the first and second connector clips.

13. The vertical curtain blind of claim 11, wherein the retention structure is configured to maintain the positioning of the clip assembly relative to the first and second panels of the respective pair of adjacent panels.

14. The vertical curtain blind of claim 11, wherein the retention structure comprises first and second longitudinally spaced retention members extending outwardly from the first connector clip.

15. The vertical curtain blind of claim 14, wherein the first and second retention members extend through the first access window and are configured to engage opposed edges of the first access window to maintain the positioning of the first connector clip relative to the first pocket.

16. The vertical curtain blind of claim 15, wherein the first and second retention members are configured to hook around the opposed edges of the access window.

17. The vertical curtain blind of claim 1, wherein each panel includes a light-transmitting portion extending vertically between the top and bottom ends of the panel and first and second light-blocking portions extending vertically between the top and bottom ends of the panel along opposed sides of the light-transmitting portion.

18. The vertical curtain blind of claim 17, wherein the first pocket of each panel extends laterally across the first light-blocking portion of the panel and the second pocket of each panel extends

laterally across the second light-blocking portion of the panel.

19. The vertical curtain blind of claim 1, wherein the first and second pockets of each panel are formed from a folded-over lateral section of the panel extending from the top end of the panel.

20. The vertical curtain blind of claim 19, wherein the first and second pockets of each panel comprise respective portions of an open-ended channel defined at least partially by the folded-over lateral section of the panel.

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